SECOND NOTICE

A screenplay
Adapted from the novella Second Notice
Running time: approx. 40 minutes

THE LOOK AND THE SOUND

- Silence is the monster's breath. No wind, no insects, no birds. When it is near, the room tone drops out of the mix. The first mosquito, at the very end, is the loveliest sound in the film.

- The knocks are the score. One is a greeting. Two is a count. Three is a verdict. Under them, a sub-bass tone at the pitch of a bell not yet struck. No orchestral music until the river.

- We never see all of it until the fire. A hand. A shoulder. A branch snapping at nine feet. Keep the left third of the frame dark.

- The flashlight is a character. When it clicks off, the screen goes fully black.

- Time is audible. Dog's watch ticks under the mix whenever his wrist is in frame. It stops at 3:40.

FADE IN:

BLACK.

HOLD on black, longer than is comfortable. A diesel engine ticks as it cools. Chains settle on a load. And we hear what is missing: no wind, no night birds, no insects.

Under it, barely there, one sub-bass tone: a bell in the instant before it is struck. It does not resolve.

From far off, wood on wood. One KNOCK. Round, polite, like a knuckle on a door.

SUPER: ALASKA. LATE JULY, 1975.

EXT. THE GRADE - NIGHT

A gouge of packed gravel cut through white spruce. A gray dusk that will never get darker.

A loaded logging truck sits dead across the road, one headlight throwing a weak yellow cone. HIGH WIDE, long lens: the truck is a toy on a brown thread laid across a huge green-black field. The spruce stand in ranks like an audience that has stopped talking.

Far back among the trunks, one is thicker and grayer than the rest, standing slightly apart. We won't notice it. We'll remember it later.

SUPER: 12:14 AM

JIM (25, skinny as a coat hanger, scraggly beard, a knit cap pulled down over his ears, a grin you would lend money to) paces the running board. Hops down. Paces the gravel. Swings the cab door open and shut. He talks the way other people sweat.

JIM
It's the alternator. No. The battery. No, it's Walt. Walt rode in this truck in June and thought, what's the single worst thing I can do to Jim's July? And here we are. A man. A truck. A dusk that won't quit.

He smacks the fender.

JIM (CONT'D)
Pipeline camps pay double on anything scaled before six. Somewhere out there a man is cashing my double right now. I can feel it leaving. Like a draft.

DOG (34, Black, tall, broad through the shoulders, big scarred hands) stands at the front tire with his hands in his jacket. He has been awake nineteen hours. He lets Jim's talk go past him like weather.

DOG
Check the fuses.

JIM
I checked the fuses. I made peace with the fuses. The fuses and I are fine.

Dog walks a slow circle around the cab. Through the window, behind the seat, a .30-06 hangs in a rack. Dog's eyes slide past it like it is a stranger on a bus.

He stops. Looks at the sky. At the trees. Nothing moves. Not a branch, not a needle, not one mosquito.

JIM
Where are the mosquitoes? I was promised mosquitoes. It's the one thing this state has going for it.

DOG
I know.

HOLD on Dog. Five full seconds. Then the camera drifts off him toward the tree line and settles on the black between two trunks. Stays there.

KNOCK. From the spruce. One. Wood on wood. It rolls across the clearing and fades.

Dog's shoulders go tight. Jim's grin goes wide. His knuckles are already up. He raps the cab door once: sharp, polite, neighborly.

JIM
Evening!

DOG
Quiet.

JIM
Every July. Same as last July. It's the payroll.

He holds up his left hand. On the palm, ballpoint ink, years old and re-inked so many times it has gone fuzzy: KNOCK BACK. TOLL. WHOLE?

JIM (CONT'D)
Pruitt's rules. First week on the grade, he made me write them on my hand like a kid. One, they knock, you knock back. Two, you leave the toll at the ford. Three, it's gotta be whole. Whole what? Pruitt never said. Pruitt said a lot of things, mostly to a jukebox.

DOG
Nothing's free out here.

JIM
Everything's free out here. That's why they send us.

He waits, grinning, for the second hello. The woods always give one more. It's the best part of the bit.

The answer comes. It is not a hello.

KNOCK. KNOCK.

Two. Slow, spaced, deliberate. A count. It doesn't roll across the clearing. It arrives.

Jim's grin holds half a second too long.

JIM (CONT'D)
Huh. That's new. Is that, like, a regional thing? An accent?

Dog takes his hands out of his pockets. He walks to the edge of the headlight's cone. A rotted stump at the shoulder of the road, knee-high, a white X spray-painted on its face. Dog's hand drifts down to his right boot, where a small leather POUCH rides against his ankle.

INSERT - THE YARD - DAY (JUNE)

Sunlight on gravel. A line of trucks. WALT (50s, short, square, pencil behind his ear) hands Jim a thick envelope. Block capitals across the flap, underlined twice: TOLL.

Jim folds it into his shirt pocket without looking at it. Grinning.

Thirty feet off, at the corner of a trailer, Dog watches him do it. Then looks at the sky.

BACK TO SCENE

DOG
Get in the cab.

JIM
You can't make me get in the cab for saying hello. They started it.

DOG
Jim.

Flat. Short. Nobody has ever said his name to him like that. Jim's face does something. He climbs into the cab.

INT. TRUCK CAB - CONTINUOUS

Jim taps the dash, nervous. Once, twice. Once, twice. The woods do not answer that. He talks to Dog through the gap in the window.

JIM
Scale of one to ten. Fear. I'm a six, but a loud six. Your turn.

DOG (O.S.)
Four.

JIM
Four! Four is a man waiting for a bus.

No answer. Jim grabs the CB mic, cord coiled like something asleep.

JIM (CONT'D)
Breaker one-nine, this is Jim, the world's unluckiest logger, calling Walt. Calling a priest. Calling anybody with a sandwich.

The hiss stops. Not fades. Stops, as if a hand has been laid over a mouth. The cab's room tone goes with it: the tick of the engine, the creak of the seat, Jim's own breath. Total vacuum. For one second we hear the pulse in his ear.

VOICE (CB)
Jim.

He laughs, one beat early.

JIM
Walt? If this is your idea of customer service...

VOICE (CB)
Jim.

Same pitch. Same pace. The horrible exactness of a tape of his own voice played back. Jim hangs up the mic gently, like something that might go off. His eyes flick to the rearview. The road. The trees. Nothing.

JIM
Radios get ghosts. It's a known thing. Dog, I want it on the record that I'm taking this extremely well.

Through the windshield, Dog is staring at him. Not afraid. Staring at him like a man staring at a clock.

DOG
Out.

JIM
Now? Two minutes ago you ordered me in...

DOG
Jim. Out.

The headlight DIPS. The beam slides down the gravel as the front of the truck rises six inches off the road.

SOUND: the bell tone returns, climbing. Coins on the dash shiver toward the edge. A ring of dust lifts off the hood in a perfect circle. The thermos in the footwell ripples in concentric rings.

DOG'S POV: the bumper lifting slowly, like a drawbridge. The chained load groans and slides. Behind the truck, the spruce are perfectly, obscenely still.

JIM
(small)
Dog.

Dog dives left into the ditch.

The truck goes over. We never see what lifts it. We see the long, slow turn of the truck in the headlight's last swing across the trees, the windshield blooming white. Then the impact, enormous. Then a hard cut to nothing: three seconds of black and total silence.

SMASH TO BLACK.

EXT. THE GRADE - WRECK - NIGHT

SUPER: 12:36 AM

A high flat WHINE, like a saw spinning down. Dog lies in the ditch with gravel in his mouth. Above him a wheel turns in the air, around and around. The picture swims, soft, as if underwater.

His hands lie in front of his face, shaking. He tells them to stop. They don't.

His hearing returns, and with it Jim, screaming his name.

Dog gets up in the wrong order, knees before hands. Goes down. Says to himself:

DOG
Up.

He gets up. The truck lies on its side across the grade, the load groaning on its chains. Dog climbs the fender and hauls the jammed passenger door open. Below him in the dark, Jim looks up, white-faced, lip split.

JIM
It picked it up, Dog.

DOG
I know. Breathe.

JIM
My leg. Get it off, get it...

The gun rack has folded across Jim's left knee. The rifle is still in it.

Dog puts a hand on the stock. Cold, like a stone pulled from a river. He hesitates. Then he pulls. The bracket gives. He works the bolt without deciding to: four rounds in the magazine. The magazine holds five. He closes the bolt and does not look at the empty space.

He slides a tire iron under the last bracket and leans. Jim screams one long word. Dog drags him out.

Jim sits on the door skin with his knee swelling like a loaf. He is sick over the side. Dog holds him by the collar.

JIM
(shivering)
It was a tree. A tree came down on the front end. Trees do that. A moose. They get unbelievably big.

DOG
Jim.

JIM
Okay. Okay. I know.

Dog gets down. On the cab's flank, six inches from his face: a HANDPRINT, driven deep into the dust and diesel above the wheel well. Five fingers spread, the palm wider than his own whole hand. The steel is dented under it. A bead of diesel runs down one finger and falls. We HEAR it land, absurdly loud.

Dog's own hand rises, trembling, and hovers beside it. Tiny.

He turns, finds a diesel can in the ditch, a long flashlight, and pushes the tire iron into Jim's fist. Jim looks at it.

JIM
A crutch. You brought me a crutch. I'm going to name it.

DOG
Walk.

EXT. THE GRADE - ROAD - NIGHT

They go down the road. Dog carries the can and the rifle. Jim hops on the iron, swearing in a high thin voice.

Behind them a binder CRACKS like a gunshot. The whole load comes off the trailer in a grinding thunder and rolls into a wall of logs across the road. The way back is closed.

Three hundred yards on, a spruce lies across the road. Fresh. The break is bright and clean, nine feet off the ground. Dog boosts Jim over. Forty yards on: another. Another. A fence of fallen trees, as far as Dog's flashlight can reach. The beam finds them one at a time, each snapping out of the dark as it arrives, like the night is being switched on in sections.

The stumps stand snapped at nine feet. No axe marks.

JIM
Beavers. Very ambitious beavers.

He sits on the third trunk, laughing, high and awful.

JIM (CONT'D)
I'd like to speak to the beavers' manager.

Behind them, a long way back: KNOCK. KNOCK. Closer than it should be.

Dog looks the other way, down the road behind them. A gap in the spruce. A blaze cut in a tree. A coffee can hanging from a wire like a lantern someone forgot to light. A footpath into the woods.

DOG
We passed it.

JIM
Passed what?

DOG
The path. To the ford.

JIM
No. We are not walking into the woods toward the thing that is throwing trees. The road. We climb the fence till it stops.

Dog points the flashlight along the line of trunks. Their snapped ends are pale as bone, pointing the way to the mill, twenty miles off. Jim stares for a long time.

JIM (CONT'D)
It's not a trap with a door, is it. It's a hall with one door open.

DOG
Yes.

JIM
(small)
I hate that you said yes.

Dog walks back down the road. At the path, the can swings on its wire. He steps onto the trail and it takes his weight the way it always has. He does not look back.

EXT. THE FOOTPATH - NIGHT

SUPER: 1:20 AM

Narrow. Spruce brushing both shoulders. Dog clicks the flashlight on for ten steps, off for ten, saving the batteries. Jim limps close behind, stepping on his heel.

When the flashlight is ON, we see the trail. When it clicks OFF, the screen goes fully black: only boots, breath, the drag of the tire iron. Each time it clicks on, something has changed. A can hangs where there was no can. A trunk leans an inch closer. We never see anything move. Only before and after.

JIM
Walk me through it. A man picks up a truck.

DOG
Not a man.

JIM
Great. Love that. So it throws trees. It builds a fence. Dog, a thing that builds a fence has plans.

DOG
Yes.

JIM
That's your whole answer?

DOG
Yes.

JIM
(a hiccup of a laugh)
I want to go home.

DOG
(quietly)
Yes.

It is the kindest thing anyone has said to Jim all week.

A COFFEE CAN hangs from a branch at face height. A twist of gray tobacco in it. Twenty yards on, another. By forty, Jim stops flinching and starts counting. Cans. Cigarettes laid across stumps like tiny logs. A pint bottle with a dime in it. A work glove nailed palm-up to a trunk. A union pin. A cracked WRISTWATCH on a string, stopped at twenty to four.

JIM
It's a yard sale. It's the quietest yard sale in the world.

Nobody laughs. He just needed to hear a joke get made.

The cans begin to TINK softly. There is no wind. A ripple of small bright sounds moves through the trees, can to can, from behind them to ahead, as if something unseen is passing close along the path, brushing each one with a fingertip. It passes Jim. It passes Dog. It keeps going. Neither man turns around.

DOG
Mind the root.

Jim steps over it. He looks at Dog. Dog stepped over the same root a second earlier without looking down, like stairs in his own house.

JIM
You know this trail.

DOG
Some.

JIM
Some. Like somebody who walks it once a year. In, I don't know. July.

Dog keeps walking. Jim stops. Looks at Dog's back. At his right boot. At the pouch.

JIM (CONT'D)
Dog. Do you leave a toll?

Dog doesn't turn. He nods, once.

JIM (CONT'D)
How long?

Dog raises both hands in the dark, in the flashlight beam. Nine fingers.

JIM (CONT'D)
Nine years? You've been tipping the forest for nine years and you let me stand there making jokes about it?

DOG
You were having fun.

Jim opens his mouth. Closes it. It's the nicest thing Dog has ever said to him, and it's on the worst night of his life.

EXT. THE PYRAMID - NIGHT

The path widens around a great flat stump. On it, a pyramid of rusted cans decades deep, a bottle at the top. A shrine, or a pile of something dead that is still being fed.

Jim stops. For six years the toll was a joke he told. He steps up to the trees like a man at a window.

JIM
I'd like to speak to whoever's in charge.

DOG
Jim.

JIM
I'm aware there's been a payment irregularity. I take full responsibility. I'd like to propose a payment plan.

His voice breaks. He keeps going. He pulls a limp, empty envelope from his shirt: TOLL on the flap.

JIM (CONT'D)
Net thirty, net sixty, whatever you want. I'm good for it. I'm not good for it. I will be. I'm sorry. I'm so sorry.

Silence. The woods listen.

Then, from the dark, a single soft KNOCK. Not the two. The old one. Hello.

Relief goes through Jim so hard he nearly sits.

JIM (CONT'D)
It took the terms. I proposed a payment plan to a forest, and the forest said sure.

He reaches out, sobbing-happy, and pinches a twist of dry tobacco from the top can. Rolls it between his fingers.

JIM (CONT'D)
Just as collateral. They'll understand. It's practically theirs, it's just sitting here...

DOG
Don't.

JIM
It's an IOU. It's a swap...

DOG
Put it back.

Jim stuffs the pinch in his jacket pocket.

The woods go silent. Not quiet. Silent, the way a room goes after somebody says the wrong name at a funeral. One drop of water falls from a branch onto the tin of a can. The sound is enormous.

Dog is looking past him, at the black between two trunks to the left of the path.

DOG
Don't move.

From ten yards off the path, a VOICE. It does not sound like it comes from ten yards. It sits in the center of the mix, close to the ear, like a man leaning over a shoulder. Behind it: ice in a glass, a jukebox playing something we almost recognize, a bar on a Friday night.

VOICE (O.S.)
Everybody goes home richer.

It is Jim's voice. Not an imitation. Jim in the cab at five in the morning, three coffees in, delighted with himself. And under it, the little pleased laugh. He has said the line a hundred times and never heard how it sounds.

It sounds like a man with his hand in somebody's pocket.

JIM
(soft)
Hey.

Because it's his voice. He knows that guy. That guy was great. That guy was never scared of anything.

VOICE (O.S.)
Everybody goes home richer.

Closer. Easy. Inviting. And behind it, a woman's laugh, a man's laugh, the clink of glasses. A place with lights. A place you could walk to.

Dog's flashlight clicks on. It lies across moss between the trunks: green, level, kind, like a lawn. Jim takes a step off the path.

His boot goes through the moss to the knee.

Cold closes on his shin. Black, old, bog stink. A fist closes on his collar and hauls. His leg comes out of the muck with a long wet suck, boot and all. He lands on his back on the trail.

DOG
Path.

The first time Jim has ever heard him say a word like a door he is holding shut.

JIM
(whisper)
Okay. Path.

The voice waits. Jim lies with his heart in his throat, leg wet to the thigh. The dark between the trees looks exactly as far away as a bar.

JIM (CONT'D)
It wasn't mocking me.

DOG
No.

JIM
It was practicing.

Dog doesn't answer. It is the answer.

EXT. HOLLIS CAMP - NIGHT

SUPER: 2:15 AM

The trees come back before the camp does. A doorframe standing alone. A clearing, gray in the dusk. A cookhouse with a tree growing from its doorway. A bunkhouse with its roof fallen across its beds. At the far edge, a truck cab nose-down in the moss, no wheels, no glass. In the middle, one enormous white spruce.

SLOW LATERAL TRACK across the ruin. Each structure is framed through the gaps of another. Wood creaking, a long shift of weight in the cookhouse, as if the building is settling around someone who isn't there.

JIM
Fixer-upper. Great bones. Motivated sellers.

Nobody picks it up. Jim is shaking, a fine hard shiver. Dog takes a spare coat from his pack and holds it out.

JIM (CONT'D)
I'm not cold.

DOG
Put it on.

He does. The sleeves cover his knuckles. In the gray he looks about fourteen.

Dog crosses to the great spruce. Nine Julys he has passed this camp from the edge of the path and never gone closer than the width of the trail. The bark has been cut in columns. His thumb finds a notch at chest height, edges gone soft and gray. Beside it, a name burned into the wood so long ago the letters have healed like scars: HOLLIS. 1931.

He moves along. 1932. 1933. A notch for every July. PRUITT. 1959. PRUITT. 1963. PRUITT. 1973.

He looks up.

TILT UP, slow. Ten feet off the ground, where no ladder has ever stood, the bark has been cut a second time above every notch. Straight as a rule. A receipt. Someone has answered every one. Above the notches of the last nine years, beside the long cut, a small neat mark. Nine of them in a row.

He puts his palm flat on the bark under them. His hand shakes. He holds it there.

JIM
(reading, lips moving)
That's a lot of marks.

Dog doesn't answer.

JIM (CONT'D)
Somebody's got a ladder.

DOG
There's no ladder.

Jim looks at Dog's hand on the bark. At the nine small cuts. Understands whose book it is.

JIM
It keeps your records.

DOG
Yes.

JIM
(gently)
Dog. That's the nicest thing a forest ever did and the creepiest.

EXT. THE OLD CAB - CONTINUOUS

Jim limps toward the wrecked cab on the slope, wanting only to be somewhere else. He steps onto the running board and stops.

JIM
Dog. There's a guy.

Behind the wheel, upright: a long-dead MAN. Canvas mackinaw. A felt hat still on the skull. Hands in his lap. Nothing broken. Nothing torn. A pocket watch hangs from the mirror on its chain, stopped at twenty to four. His boots are set neatly together. He looks composed, like a man who dressed for it.

JIM (CONT'D)
Mannequin. Hunting camp thing. They do this.

DOG
Look at the watch.

Jim looks. Twenty to four. Like the one on the string. He backs off the step, hand over his mouth.

JIM
I'm going to sit. Just for a minute.

DOG
No.

Dog catches his arm. It comes out harder than he meant.

DOG (CONT'D)
He sat down. He waited. Every man who stopped on this path died at twenty to four.

JIM
That's not a rule. That's you making a rule.

DOG
Yes.

Jim looks at the watch again. Then at Dog's wrist. Dog's own watch ticks, loud now in the mix: 2:21.

JIM
It's two twenty.

DOG
We keep moving.

An AMBER LIGHT begins to glow on the dead man's dashboard. It brightens slowly, the way a tube set warms. There is no battery. The glow climbs the dead man's face from below, a plain, domestic, kitchen-at-night yellow, which is the most frightening thing on screen. A low hum. The tick of metal expanding as it heats.

A click. A rush of static, soft as rain on a roof. Then a man's voice, grainy and warm and impatient.

WALT (V.O.)
Jimmy? Jimmy, where the hell are you?

Jim goes still.

JIM
That's Walt.

DOG
No.

WALT (V.O.)
If you're not on that scale by six I'm docking you the whole load. And I'm docking your mother.

Jim laughs, a high helpless bark. His whole body goes loose.

JIM
Dog. Listen to him. Nobody else does the mother thing.

DOG
Walt's at the yard. Twenty miles.

JIM
He drove out for the Hendricks thing.

DOG
Once.

JIM
Once is a precedent.

DOG
Ask him something.

Jim wets his lips and leans to the dial.

JIM
What did you short us in March?

WALT (V.O.)
Forty-one dollars and a scale discrepancy, and I'd do it again.

Jim's face crumples with joy.

JIM
It's him!

DOG
You told the whole yard.

JIM
(a beat)
I did tell the whole yard. I was upset.

WALT (V.O.)
(fatherly, warm as whiskey)
Jimmy. You leave the toll?

The camp goes quiet.

WALT (V.O.) (CONT'D)
It's in your pocket. It weighs nothing. You spent it on the truck.

Jim's mouth opens. He does not look at Dog.

JIM
Course I've got it. Right here. Safe and sound.

WALT (V.O.)
Good boy. Then there's no problem. Come out the muskeg road. I've got the Dodge and both headlights on.

Through the broken wall of the bunkhouse, far off in the trees: TWO PALE LIGHTS, side by side, a car's width apart. They do not flicker.

JIM
Walt! We're coming! Hold the sandwich!

DOG
Jim...

Jim is already hopping, tire iron banging. Some small clear part of him knows it is wrong, the way you know a step is missing in the dark, and he goes anyway, because it is a light, and every light he's seen all night has been pointed at him.

EXT. THE X LINE - NIGHT

The lights are not headlights. They are SPHERES, each the size of a grapefruit, hanging a yard off the ground without a wire. Cold milk-white light. No beam. Jim sees his face in one, small and bent, like a face in a spoon.

JIM
Swamp gas. Methane. It's in a book.

Between the trunks every thirty yards: two saplings bent and lashed crosswise high between trees, forming an X. Another. Another. A line of them dwindling into the dark.

JIM (CONT'D)
Somebody's been doing crafts.

WALT (O.S.)
Jimmy! What the hell are you doing with those lights? I'm over here! Come left!

So exactly Walt. The annoyance. The idiot. Jim steps off the trail past the last X. The lights dim to ash. The needles underfoot give a soft sigh.

WALT (O.S.) (CONT'D)
That's my boy. Right here.

JIM
Dog! I'm going left! Walt's on the left!

No answer. The milk-white light behind him has shrunk to two faint coins. A smell drifts in, sweet and sharp: wet dog and struck matches. Jim has never smelled that on Walt. Walt smells like diesel and Winstons.

He stops.

JIM (CONT'D)
(small)
Walt?

WALT (O.S.)
Keep going.

And then, softly, in another register, the voice laughs. It is Jim's own laugh. The high helpless bark, copied down to the last crack.

Jim turns to run. The ground gives.

It goes out from under him with a long wet sigh. Cold takes his legs, his hips, his chest. He flings out both arms and gets nothing: moss, water, black mud closing around his ribs like a fist. The tire iron slips from his hand and vanishes without a sound.

Far behind him, someone is shouting his name, over and over, ragged, getting no closer.

EXT. THE MUSKEG - NIGHT

SUPER: 2:40 AM

Dog bursts out of the spruce at a dead run and stops at the edge of a flat sheet of moss, green-gray, perfectly smooth. In the middle, a black hole the size of a tabletop. In the hole: Jim, to the chest, arms spread, mud to the chin.

JIM
Hi. I'm in a swamp.

DOG
Don't move.

JIM
I wasn't planning on it. I'm going to die in a place with a moose name.

Dog goes down on his belly. He wraps the pack strap twice around his fist, sets the rifle on a root well back, and slides out across the quivering moss. Four feet. Eight. At twelve he throws the strap out.

DOG
Don't talk. Pull when I pull.

HANDHELD at moss level. The mat BREATHES, a slow swell under Dog's chest. We hold a long time on each pull. A crack races out under Dog's chin like a thin black vein. Jim's face at the bog's edge, only his eyes clear of the mud, milk-white light in each. Pull. Rest. Pull.

On the fifth pull the strap tears from the pack. Jim shoots backward onto the moss. The pack tips and goes down slowly, like something being lowered: two sandwiches, the thermos, the first-aid tin. The flashlight slides after it, throws its yellow beam up at the sky for one second, and the bog takes it.

Dog lies on his face, arms outflung. His left hand is still wrapped through the strap of the diesel can. He doesn't remember putting it there.

JIM
(on his back, black from the chin down)
For the record, I never liked that thermos.

Dog strips the soaked coat off Jim, wrings it, and wraps his own jacket around Jim's shoulders. He stands in his shirtsleeves and says nothing about the cold.

Two pale lights have come to the edge of the clearing, hanging exactly where the spruce meets the moss. They hold the margin like a flagman at a landing. Dog studies them. The lights flared when he stood inside the line of X's. They dimmed when Jim crossed the last one.

DOG
Stay in the light.

JIM
Is that a rule you just made up?

DOG
Yes.

JIM
Good. It's got a nice ring.

Jim sits up. The grin lifts off his face all at once, as if someone reached in and took it. What is left is younger and a little ugly: a kid with his eyes too wide.

JIM (CONT'D)
Dog. I have to say something. And then you say something, and then we never talk about it again, and we're normal.

His black hands shake in front of him.

JIM (CONT'D)
I spent it. The envelope. Six hundred dollars. Monday I was two payments behind on the Kenworth, and the woman at the lender's, Deb, had the paper on the desk and a pen in her hand. I thought, I'll make it up on overtime. Nobody'll ever know. I put it on her desk and she said, oh, thank you, that really helps. And I walked out into the sunshine and thought, I'm the smartest man in Alaska.

His breath hitches.

JIM (CONT'D)
And last year I only left half. Three hundred. I told you it was handled.

DOG
I know.

Jim's head comes up.

JIM
What?

DOG
I saw it in June. In the yard. I saw you fold it. I saw you not look.

JIM
And you didn't say anything?

DOG
No.

JIM
Why?

Dog turns the rifle over in his hands.

DOG
It wasn't mine to say.

It does not sound good out loud. Jim stares at him. For a moment he might laugh, or cry, or hit something. He does none of it.

JIM
Okay. So we're a pair. We both knew, we both said nothing, and now we're standing in a swamp at three in the morning. That is a very efficient way to ruin a night.

It is the first true thing Dog has heard him say with no joke around it.

JIM (CONT'D)
So we pay. We follow the lights, we get to the ford, we pay it. Double. Whatever it wants.

He opens his wallet. His face falls.

JIM (CONT'D)
I have eleven dollars.

DOG
I have forty.

JIM
Fifty-one. We owe six hundred, and the woods have an interest rate.

They step back inside the line of X's. The lights brighten. Twenty yards on, Dog sees it.

At the far edge of the bog, where the light stops, something low crosses the black. It comes from behind a stump on four limbs, shoulders higher than hips, and there is something about the way it moves that the eye will not settle on, as if the angles are wrong. Dog's hand goes to the rifle sling. He cannot make the arm lift. The thing crosses the margin of the light in one long stride, and the next takes it into the trees. The moss behind it does not move at all.

SOUND: the footfall arrives late, a full second after the foot lands, as if sound is having to catch up. Dog's breathing drops out of the mix completely.

JIM
That's a bear.

DOG
Bears don't bend like that.

JIM
It was a very flexible bear.

DOG
Jim.

JIM
It was a bear, Dog.

They walk. Jim says it again a hundred yards on, and again at two hundred, each time louder, until he is saying it to the whole forest. Dog doesn't correct him. He keeps his eyes on the lights and does not look left again.

EXT. THE FOOTPATH - NIGHT

SUPER: 3:05 AM

A mile after the bog, nothing happens. Jim waits for it. His shoulders come down an inch. Dog walks ahead in his shirtsleeves.

JIM
Can I ask you something? You don't have to answer. The quiet. Did you practice it?

DOG
No.

A can swings on its wire. Tick. Tick.

JIM
I don't know your name. I'm not asking. I just want it noted I never asked. Six years. I figured if you wanted me to have it you'd say it, and then it got too late. It's like not knowing what's under a bandage.

DOG
Noted.

One word. Jim holds on to it for another hundred yards.

JIM
New theory. It's not a monster. It's a landlord. It keeps a ledger. It sends a notice, you ignore the notice, and then it's furniture in the street...

DOG
Second notice.

Jim stops walking.

JIM
Was that a joke?

Dog doesn't turn. But his shoulders move once, and it isn't the cold.

JIM (CONT'D)
Oh my God. He's funny. Six years I've been carrying this act and the man had a bit the whole time.

DOG
Walk.

JIM
I'm walking so hard.

EXT. THE STUMP - NIGHT

The path spills into a small round clearing. In the middle stands a black stump, waist-high and wide as a table, hollow, with a lid of rough planks lashed down with wire. The X's stand around it in a ring. The two pale lights hang at the edge.

Dog lifts the wire and raises the lid.

Inside, the hollow has been planed smooth. A four-foot board stands propped against the back, pale and covered with marks. A LEDGER: ruled into rows and columns. Down the first column, names burned in with a hot iron: HOLLIS. PRUITT. A string of names from the yard. Beside each, rows of notches. Mostly full. A few short.

Below PRUITT, a new name, black, the wood still pale around the letters: JIM.

Jim reads under it, lips moving, like his own medical chart. 1974: a half notch, and cut deep beside it, half, owing. 1975: a whole notch, owing. Then a single clean line ruled across the wood. Under the line, a tally cut deep: one long stroke and one short.

JIM
One and a half. One and a half what? Dollars? Is that dollars?

DOG
Wholes.

He holds up his left hand. The ink on his palm is smeared to a bruise: WHOLE?

JIM
Pruitt said it. Right to my face. They don't care how much. They care that it's whole. I wrote it on my hand. I thought it was a loophole.

He digs out his wallet with shaking hands. Lays his eleven on the lid. Dog, without a word, lays his forty on top. The bills look pale and absurd in the milk-white light.

Nothing.

JIM (CONT'D)
Please.

HOLD. The clearing, the stump, the bills. Ten seconds with nothing in it but breathing. We are listening for an answer. So is Jim.

KNOCK. KNOCK. KNOCK.

Three, from all around them.

JIM (CONT'D)
It was two before. What's three?

A STONE comes out of the dark, fist-sized. It strikes the lid with a crack like a pistol, six inches from the bills. The money flies off like leaves. A second stone lands ten feet down the trail and sinks into the earth and stays. A third beside it. They sit in the dirt like gateposts.

They were not thrown at them. They landed exactly where they landed. One told them what the money was worth. Two told them where to go.

Jim kneels in the moss and gathers the scattered bills one at a time, smoothing each. His hands have stopped shaking. It is somehow worse.

He takes the damp pinch of tobacco from his pocket and sets it gently on the lid. As he pulls his hand away, in the ledger under his name, a new mark appears: a scratch the size of a grain of rice. He did not see it happen.

JIM (CONT'D)
Dog. What does it want?

DOG
I don't know.

He doesn't sound like he's lying. He sounds afraid of the answer.

The two stones sit in the trail ahead like a doorway. Dog goes first. Jim follows. Around them, steady as weather:

KNOCK. KNOCK. KNOCK.

EXT. THE FOOTPATH - NIGHT

A CRACK splits the dusk ahead. A two-hundred-year-old spruce decides to leave. It comes down across the trail thirty yards on, a hundred feet of crown tearing through its neighbors. Needles rain. When the noise dies the trunk lies across the trail, too wide to climb, a root ball on one end the height of a house.

JIM
It's not going to let us cut through. It's going to make us go the way it likes.

Dog stabs the rifle butt into the moss along the root ball's flank. An inch, then stops. Again, farther out. Solid.

DOG
Left. Step where I step.

JIM
You're sure?

DOG
No.

JIM
Scale of one to ten.

DOG
Seven.

Jim looks at him a long moment. It is the first time the number has moved.

They go around. Ten steps. At the sixth, the INFRASOUND hits: a slow flat pressure rising out of the earth, pressing the air from Dog's chest. The picture begins to shudder at a frequency just beneath sight; the image doubles, trembles, its edges ghosting. Color drains toward black and white. The pale lights ahead go to ash. Then the smell: wet dog and struck matches.

JIM
Dog. Something's on the ground.

At the edge of the dark, ten feet off, something lies low on the moss, long and flat and moving, belly almost to the ground, at a pace too even to be anything but intent. It is coming toward Jim.

JIM (CONT'D)
Shoot it shoot it shoot it, Dog,
shoot it...

Nine years the rifle has ridden in the rack. His hands come up without being asked. The stock settles into his shoulder as if it had been waiting there. He puts the sight on the low shape.

DOG
(flat, level)
Stay quiet. Watch the trees.

The thing stops. Then it rises.

ONE SHOT, no cut. Low, from Jim's POV on the ground: it unfolds up through the frame, hands first, then shoulders, then a back like a wall, past the height of a man, until the dark has a shape in it nine feet tall. We see a chest, a throat, nothing more. We do not see the face until Dog does.

It is looking at Dog. Across the brow, a pale seam of scar. A ridge healed from a long old cut.

It knows him.

Dog's finger moves.

Jim lunges. A shoulder crosses the sight, Jim's, in Dog's jacket, shoving up between the muzzle and the shape. He will never know if Jim meant the shape or the man.

BANG.

The roar rolls away through the trunks. For one frame the muzzle flash prints the creature on the dark as a white negative, tall and still. Then gone. The gunshot is the only loud thing in the film so far, and it takes everything else with it. A long high sine tone, and under it Dog's heartbeat.

Jim lies on his side with both hands clamped to his chest under the arm. Between his fingers something black is coming, fast and steady. His eyes are open. He is looking at Dog.

The thing is gone. Dog never sees it go. Only the pressure lifting and the smell thinning and the silence.

DOG
Jim.

He drops to his knees, rips open his own jacket on Jim's shoulders. The hole is high and clean, and bleeding steadily. He presses his palm flat to it.

JIM
(calm, astonished)
You put it in me.

DOG
Hold still.

JIM
You aimed at... you aimed...

DOG
Don't talk.

Ahead, where the trail rejoins beyond the root ball, the two lights have come back up. They are no longer white. They are red.

The red does not light the scene so much as stain it. Every trunk gains a red edge, every face a red cheek. The color follows them until the river.

EXT. THE FOOTPATH - NIGHT

SUPER: 3:12 AM

The red light on Dog's face makes him look burned already. His hands press on the wound hard enough to hurt, then not hurt. Jim lies in the moss. His breath has a small whistle at the top of it, like a kettle a long way off.

JIM
You aimed at me.

It comes out thin. He meant a fist. It comes out like a question asked on a bus.

JIM (CONT'D)
I think I stepped in front of it. Did I step? Dog. Did I step in front?

Dog's jaw moves once. His eyes stay on the blood.

JIM (CONT'D)
It looked at you. Not me. When the flash went. It was looking at you. And you looked back.

DOG
Later.

JIM
That's not an answer.

DOG
No.

He tears off his own sleeve in one pull. Folds it into a pad. Binds Jim's chest tight enough that the sky goes white at the edges.

JIM
That's your only shirt. We're sharing one person's worth of clothes...

DOG
Quiet.

The gentlest word he has ever said. The rifle lies where it fell, a thin line of smoke still rising from the bore, straight up in the windless cold. Dog looks at it a long time. Then he lays it down a few feet off with the barrel turned away from them both.

JIM
Take it. It's got three left.

DOG
I know how many.

JIM
There's a thing out there with a face, and you can't just...

DOG
I shot you.

Flat. Not an apology. A number read off a scale, said to the moss. Jim closes his mouth.

He tries to sit up. A mistake. The whole left side of his body goes white and loud. Dog's arm goes under his shoulders, the other under his knees, and he lifts him. Jim doesn't fight it.

Dog carries him around the root ball, testing each step with a boot. The count has stopped. The woods stand in the red light like people at the back of a church.

JIM
It took a deposit, Dog.

DOG
Don't say that.

Jim looks up at his face and understands that Dog is afraid it's true.

Something walks with them. Off in the trees to the left, a hundred yards away, not trying to hide. Every few seconds a branch snaps high up, nine feet, ten, in step with Dog's own.

JIM
Escort.

DOG
Don't look.

Jim closes his eyes. He reaches for a joke. His hand closes on nothing.

JIM
I'm going to die owing Walt money.

It's so stupid he laughs. The laugh turns to a cough. The cough tastes like pennies.

EXT. TRAPLINE CABIN - NIGHT

Beyond the last red light, in a small clearing, a dark shape crouches under the spruce. A trapline cabin: silver logs, a slumped stovepipe, a rusted latch. The black windows look out at the trail like eyes that have waited a long time to be asked.

Dog kicks the door in.

INT. TRAPLINE CABIN - NIGHT

Mice. Cold ash. Under that, tobacco. A bunk against the far wall with a moth-eaten blanket. A sheet-iron stove. Red light from the window lies on the floor in a long thin shape like a spill.

Dog lowers Jim onto the bunk an inch at a time. Jim makes a small sound through his teeth and goes quiet.

Dog's watch: 3:21. He looks at it a while.

Every log, floor to roof pole, has been cut and scratched and burned. Initials. Years. Tallies in a hundred hands. Waiting. Waiting. Day 3. And along the beam above the door, one under another, like a list: R.H. 3:40. T.O. 3:40. W.B. 3:40. E.L. 3:40.

Thirty-one of them. All the same hour. The last, E.M., is cut clean with a good knife, and the year beside it is 1969.

In the silence a pocket watch somewhere in the cabin is ticking. We search for it. We never find it.

JIM
It's a sign-in sheet.

DOG
Don't sign it.

He unwinds the pad. The hole is small and clean and will not stop. He needs to wash it and has nothing to wash it with. Over the stove, a shelf: twists of tobacco in oilcloth, stiff gloves, and bottles, dozens of them, coffee cans and jars and flasks, each with a bit of tape tied to its neck. Every toll men carried this far and lost their nerve over, and left in the last dry place before the ford, meaning to come back.

He takes down a bottle of whiskey. The tape on its neck: W.H. 1957. The seal is unbroken. He stands holding it a long time. Then he breaks the seal.

JIM
Save some for the wake.

DOG
This'll hurt.

JIM
Everything does. I'm very good at it.

He pours it into the hole. Jim's body goes rigid. The sound that comes out of him is one Dog has heard once, from a horse. Dog holds him down by the shoulder. When it's over Jim lies with his mouth open and tears running into his ears. Dog tears a strip off the blanket, makes a clean pad, binds it tighter with hands that do not shake.

He notices that. They shook for two hours. Now, when it counts, they are steady.

He gives Jim a swallow. Jim coughs, swallows again.

JIM
That's a nineteen fifty-seven.

DOG
Be quiet.

JIM
I'm appreciating it.

Dog's watch: 3:27. The cabin is warm and dry. It is the first place in three hours where nothing has happened. He sits back on his heels. He feels it working on him, a hand at the back of his neck. Sit down. You've done enough.

He stands.

The SHADOW slides across the wall.

It comes in at the window out of the red light and lies down slowly across the logs. A hand. Five fingers spread, laid on the glass from outside, each longer than Dog's forearm. The red light makes it black and huge. It doesn't move. The window frame gives a faint dry creak: weight leaning on old wood.

Each time Dog's watch ticks, loud in the mix, the shadow shifts a hair. We realize we are watching it count.

JIM
(small and clear)
Dog. It's there.

DOG
I see it.

JIM
What's it doing?

The hand lies on the glass, not pushing, not reaching. It rests like a hand on a doorframe.

DOG
Keeping time.

His watch: 3:29.

DOG (CONT'D)
We go.

JIM
You said ten minutes...

DOG
We go now.

For one second Dog thinks he will argue. Then Jim says, with no joke anywhere in his voice:

JIM
Okay.

Dog lifts him. Puts the bottle inside his shirt, because it is a toll and he doesn't know what else to do with it. Carries him out.

EXT. TRAPLINE CABIN - CONTINUOUS

The porch is empty. The window is empty. On the doorstep lies a STICK.

A peeled spruce branch as long as his arm, a loop of bark cord tied round one end, a row of notches cut in it. It was not there when he went in. He knows it from the hundred on the shelf. He picks it up one-handed with Jim's weight against his chest.

One long notch and one short. Jim's. A gap, and in a column of its own, a third notch as long as the others and cut as deep. And beside it, small and neat, in the same careful hand as the nine marks on the tree: his own.

It is a second account, opened beside the first, and cut so fresh the wood inside is wet. The notch is for the shot.

JIM
(eyes half shut)
What's that?

Dog puts the stick inside his shirt with the bottle.

DOG
Kindling.

Behind him, in the trees, softly, a single knock. The old one. The greeting. Almost kind: someone coming up the walk at the end of the day with a hat in his hand and a paper in his coat.

Dog's watch: 3:34. Six minutes.

He walks.

EXT. THE FOOTPATH - NIGHT

The knock comes every thirty seconds now. Soft, round, polite. From behind. From ahead. Once, impossibly, from beside Jim's ear.

Jim's eyes drift to the open collar of Dog's shirt, to the end of a pale peeled stick. Two notches, a gap, a third in its own column, and beside it a small neat mark like a signature.

JIM
That's not kindling.

Dog's step doesn't change.

JIM (CONT'D)
The two notches. That's mine. That's from the stump. The other one's not mine. Whose is it?

Dog's jaw moves. That is all.

JIM (CONT'D)
Put me down. If I'm down you could make the ford. It's me it wants...

DOG
No.

JIM
Dog.

DOG
No.

Loud enough to ring. The trees give it back. Dog stops in the middle of the trail with Jim in his arms and the red lights on both sides, and for the first time Jim sees that his face is wet. He is crying without a sound, without moving, as he does everything.

Then the knocking stops. Not fades. Cuts off in the middle of its own silence, like a clock.

The red lights give one slow pulse and hold. In the hush, Jim hears Dog's WATCH ticking against his ear, so steady he'd stopped hearing it. He hears each tick separately. He hears the one that comes after the last one before it stops.

The whistle in his chest goes out like a candle.

There is no pain in it. His breath goes up out of him slowly, like a drawer being drawn. The lights go out one by one. Dog's voice, shouting, a long way up, grows small as a voice at the other end of a pipe.

SOUND DESIGN: every sound in the film leaves, in the order we learned it. The knocks, gone. The breathing, gone. Last, Dog's watch. Then absolute silence, three full seconds of black, the longest in the film.

BLACK.

EXT. THE YARD - DAY (JUNE)

Sun on gravel. A line of trucks, chrome shining. SOUND: crickets, flies, a diesel idling, a screen door, laughter across the yard. The first insects we have heard in the film. After all that silence it is almost too much. The image is blown out, overexposed, flaring like a memory.

Jim stands in the yard, and he is also watching himself stand in the yard. Walt holds out the envelope.

WALT
Thirty of 'em. Count it if you want.

JIM (JUNE)
I trust you.

His own voice, bright and quick. He watches himself fold the envelope into his shirt pocket without looking at it. He watches his own face, and the grin on it. He has never seen it from outside. A beautiful grin. A grin you would lend money to.

Thirty feet off, at the corner of a trailer, Dog stands with his hands in his jacket, looking at the sky.

VOICE (O.S.)
Whole?

It comes from his own mouth, in the yard in June, in the voice of a man three coffees in and about to be right.

JIM
No.

VOICE (O.S.)
What do you keep in front of it?

He knows the answer. He has known it since he could talk.

JIM (CONT'D)
Talking.

VOICE (O.S.)
(kindly)
Whole is what's left when you take away what you hide behind.

It is so simple he could weep. He has spent his life paying in change.

JIM (CONT'D)
(a whisper)
Take it.

Something reaches into him, gently, and takes it.

EXT. THE FOOTPATH - NIGHT

A mouth on his mouth. Breath going in, big and ragged, tasting of whiskey and blood. A fist hammering his chest. A voice breaking over him like a wave.

DOG
Jim. Come back. Come on, you stupid... Come on...

Jim COUGHS. It comes up in a great raw heave. Air goes in, burning. He rolls on his side in the needles and breathes, a long wet drag with a hole in it, and the world comes back: ground first, then sky, then red light on the trees.

Dog kneels beside him, shaking head to foot, shirt in rags, hands bloody to the wrist, his whole face open with nothing in front of it.

On Dog's wrist, the watch has stopped. It says twenty to four.

DOG (CONT'D)
You're breathing.

Jim looks up at him. He opens his mouth. He has the biggest, funniest, bravest thing in the world to say. He reaches for it. His throat makes a small dry sound like paper tearing.

Nothing. Not a word. He tries again. Nothing but air. He has been given back his life and left without the thing he spent it on.

Dog puts a hand on his face and keeps it there.

Far off in the red-lit trees, one knock: gentle, kind. And Jim hears in it, for the first time, what it is. The sound of someone who has been paid part of something, and is willing to wait for the rest.

EXT. THE FOOTPATH - NIGHT

SUPER: 4:05 AM

The watch says twenty to four. Over the spruce, the gray has gone a shade thinner, the color of dishwater.

Dog carries Jim. Jim's head is on his shoulder, eyes half shut, awake. For the first time in six years the quiet between them isn't Dog's. It is Jim's, and enormous. It walks with them like a third man.

DOG
I'm going to say something. You can't answer. That's fine. It's easier. I'm not good at this. I'd like that noted.

Jim's eyes open, dark in the red light.

DOG (CONT'D)
In sixty-six I was twenty-five. Pruitt's crew. One night in July I came out of the bunkhouse to piss, and there was something crossing the road.

INSERT - PRUITT'S LANDING - NIGHT (1966)

A YOUNG DOG (25) in a bunkhouse doorway, barefoot, rifle in hand. Across the cleared dusk, low on all fours, something crosses the road. It stops. It stands, the way you stand when somebody comes in. As if being polite. Its face is broad and flat and unscarred.

DOG (V.O.)
I put the sight on the middle of it. It didn't do anything. It looked at me like you'd look at somebody who owes you.

The young man fires. The bark of a tree beside its head EXPLODES in splinters. The creature raises a hand to its brow. When it lowers the hand, a long line of blood. It looks at him. Then it drops to all fours and goes into the trees without a sound.

BACK TO SCENE

DOG
I don't know if I missed on purpose. I wanted to hit it. I think I wanted not to. I wanted both, and I got the one. In the morning I went out to the ford with half my pouch and left it under the stone. I thought I might be forgiven. I wasn't. It just kept saying hello. Nine Julys. I never told anybody. I put the rifle in the rack so that if I ever got the idea again, it'd be right there where I'd have to look at it.

Something touches his sternum. Jim's knuckle. Jim has worked a hand up between them and made a loose fist, and with one finger he taps the bone of Dog's chest. Once. Soft. Round.

The old knock. I'm here.

Dog's throat closes. He walks ten steps before he can use it.

DOG (CONT'D)
I saw the envelope in June. I told you it wasn't mine to say. That was a lie. It was mine. Last summer I found your half under the stone, untouched. I should have told you then. I thought, he's going to skip it, and I thought, good. Nine years it was me out there alone on my knees with a pouch of leaf, and I wanted one year where I wasn't the only one.

He breathes, a ragged shudder.

DOG (CONT'D)
I wanted it to land on somebody else. I let it land on you.

A tear runs sideways out of Jim's eye and into his hair.

DOG (CONT'D)
And the shot. I said I don't know. It's the truth. It rose, and I saw its face, and my finger moved. Same distance as sixty-six. I don't know if I fired at it or at the thing in me that wanted it to stop looking. You stepped. I saw you step. It doesn't help. It's the same question. Nine years, and I got to ask it twice.

It is more words than he has said in a row in his life. He walks on, and the load is lighter.

DOG (CONT'D)
My name is...

He says it.

The river has begun to roar somewhere ahead. Its sound swells and takes the word whole. We see Dog's lips shape something short and plain and ordinary. We do not hear it.

Jim's lips move. They shape it once, without breath, and keep it.

Dog laughs, a cracked awful helpless sound.

DOG (CONT'D)
That's all. Six years. That's all it was.

Jim's finger taps again. Once. Twice.

Jim works a hand into the inside pocket of the jacket he is wearing, Dog's own, and draws out a flat metal TIN, scratched, the size of a deck of cards. Waterproof matches. Dog put the jacket on Jim in the bog and has not thought of it since. Jim presses the tin into his hand and closes Dog's fingers around it.

Then, from ahead and below, through the trunks: a long steady HISS. A river. And under it, a low even throb like a heart.

DOG (CONT'D)
Generator. That's Camp Nine. Half a mile.

Behind them, in the trees, a single knock. Ahead, the river waits. Dog walks.

EXT. THE FOOTPATH - NIGHT

SUPER: 4:30 AM

The branches stop snapping at nine feet. A twig cracks at four. At three. At a man's knee. It is not a step. It is a run.

Something runs beside them in the dark, low, on the left, at the edge of the red light, faster than a man and quieter than wind. Jim turns his head and sees a long back go by, bunched and rolling, shoulders higher than hips. It crosses the trail ahead. It circles behind. It comes up on the left again. Easy, almost lazy, the way a dog runs alongside a car.

HANDHELD at Dog's hip, long lens. The runner is never in focus: only movement at the frame's edge, a deeper dark moving through the dark. It is not attacking. It is herding. Every time Dog's pace slows, it is there at the edge of the light, and Dog's pace picks up.

DOG
It wants us at the water.

Dog runs. Every stride goes through Jim like a hammer through a plank. He bites the inside of his cheek and keeps his eyes open. The roar grows until it is the only sound in the world.

The trail drops. The spruce fall away. Dog skids down a bank of loose gravel, nearly falls, catches himself.

EXT. THE FORD - FIRST LIGHT

The river lies across the whole bottom of the night: eighty yards wide, black and silver, running hard, white water chopping over rocks. The sky above has gone the color of a pearl.

On the far bank: LIGHTS. Yellow work lamps on poles, steady and warm and electric. Trailers. A water tank. A generator throbbing. Somebody over there is making coffee.

Jim begins, silently, to cry.

Dog sets him down against a rock. Turns. On a half-moon of shingle, where the trail ends: the CAIRN.

As tall as Dog. A great rough heap of river stones built up over decades, and not stones only. Axes with silver handles. Bucksaw blades. Calked boots, laces knotted together. Gloves. Hard hats. Union pins. A fiddle with no strings. And watches: hundreds upon hundreds, on straps and chains, hung from every crack, glinting in the red light.

Every one of them is ticking.

It comes as a soft hum of tiny sound, a hall full of clocks. At first a hundred watches tick out of sync. Slowly they align, tick by tick, into one steady pulse, like a congregation beginning to breathe together.

At the foot of the cairn, a big flat STONE, and around it a ring of old black ash where a hundred years of men built a hundred small fires.

Dog goes to the stone. Puts both hands under its edge. Lifts.

Under it: a flat bundle in oilcloth. He unwraps it. Mottled with green, curled with damp: fifteen twenty-dollar bills.

DOG
It never took it. Last year. It left it.

Jim looks from the bills to Dog's face and back. He sees the whole thing at once. A half payment left under a stone in the rain. Not taken. Not refused. Kept, as a clerk keeps a short payment in a drawer, with a note pinned to it.

At the edge of the clearing, the running thing has halted at the border of the spruce. It rises in one long unfolding until a shape stands against the trunks nine feet tall and still, a darker piece of the dark. A pale line across the brow where the red light catches. It is watching.

Jim pushes himself up on his elbows. Gets his heels under him. Looks across thirty feet of gravel at the shape in the trees and opens his mouth.

Nothing comes out.

He tries again. A whisper of air, no sound. He looks at Dog. Dog looks back. Jim shuts his mouth and does the only thing he can. He mouths it, slowly, carefully, so there can be no mistake. Plain white SUBTITLES, no sound:

JIM
(mouthed, subtitled)
I took the money.

The shape does not move.

JIM (CONT'D)
(mouthed, subtitled)
Thirty men. Twenty dollars each. Walt wrote TOLL on it in capitals. I put it on a desk in town and a woman said thank you. Last year I left half. I said it was a bad month. It was never a bad month.

His chest is burning. He keeps on.

JIM (CONT'D)
(mouthed, subtitled)
I thought you were Pruitt's joke. You knocked and I knocked back to make fun of you. Every July. I thought it was funny. I'm sorry I made it a joke.

That is all. He has nothing behind it: no grin in front, no next sentence waiting. He sits on the gravel with the river roaring and his empty hands in his lap and lets the thing look at him.

Nobody moves. The generator throbs. A hundred watches tick.

From the trees, softly: a single knock.

It is a long time before Jim understands that it is an answer and not a greeting. The sound of a ledger being opened to a page.

Dog goes down on his knees at the ash ring and moves fast, with a job in front of him. He digs a hole in the old ash with his hands. He takes the POUCH out of his boot, worn pale and soft as a glove, holds it against his chest for one second, and lays it in the center of the pit. He sets the notched stick beside it. He builds a small tight cone of bleached driftwood over both. He unscrews the cap of the diesel can and pours. He pours the last of the 1957 over it, and it runs down into the wood and shines.

He takes the tin from his pocket. Opens it. Small neat dark-headed matches, like a row of seeds. He strikes one.

It breaks. The head snaps off and falls on the gravel.

His hand is shaking again, like a leaf. Jim watches him see it.

DOG
(to his own hand)
Don't.

He strikes a second. It flares: a tiny orange tongue. He cups it and brings it down toward the wood, and the cold comes down off the trees.

The pressure, flat and slow, rolling off the dark like a tide. The flame leans. Shrinks. Goes blue and thin and out.

Dog kneels with a dead match between his fingers. He draws a third. His hand won't hold it. The head quivers against the box and will not strike. A low helpless sound comes out of him, the sound of someone who has run a very long way and found the door locked.

Jim drags himself across the gravel.

It takes a long time. He crosses twelve feet on his elbows and one good knee with the hole in his chest tearing at every pull. He comes up against Dog's shoulder and puts out both hands. They are black with blood and mud and shake like Dog's. He cups them around the match and around Dog's fingers, and holds on.

Dog looks down. He draws a long breath and strikes.

The match lights between their four hands: a tiny orange flower. The pressure comes down on them. The flame bends and shudders, and they hold it, the two of them, in a cave of fingers, in the dark and the cold and the noise of the river, until it is steady.

Dog puts it to the wood.

The diesel takes with a soft WHUMP. Blue flame runs across the cone and up, and orange follows, and the light climbs the cairn, leaping from axe to axe, from watch to watch, a hundred little suns flashing and swinging on their chains. Smoke goes up in a thick sweet column and bends toward the trees.

At the edge of the clearing, in the glow of the toll fire, the nine-foot shape takes one slow step forward onto the gravel.

EXT. THE FORD - THE TOLL FIRE - DAWN

It stands at the edge of the firelight, upright, a little bent with age. Gray hair, long and matted with burrs. Shoulders wide as a doorway. Arms hanging to its knees, hands open at its sides, palms forward, empty, held out as for change. A broad, old, tired face, a pale scar across the brow. Dark wet clear eyes: the eyes of someone who has waited a very long time at a counter and never once raised his voice.

The first time we see it whole. One wide frame, held, no cutting. The fire throws its shadow nine feet high across the cairn and a thousand watches, and they flash in it like eyes. We are finally allowed to look. It does not look at us. It looks at Dog.

It is not terrible. It is only very large, and old, and waiting for him to finish.

Dog kneels. He wants to say a clear thing first, to set down in front of it like a plate. His mouth is dry.

DOG
In sixty-six I fired at you from the door of a bunkhouse. You'd done nothing. You'd stopped to look at me. I was afraid, and I fired.

His voice cracks. He begins again.

DOG (CONT'D)
I've paid every year since and I never said I was sorry. I thought the tobacco said it for me. Tonight I fired again. I don't know where I aimed. He was in front of me. He's all I've got. I shot him. I took a man's whiskey off a shelf to wash it. And I watched him pocket the toll in June and said nothing, because I wanted somebody else to owe.

Behind him in the dark, Jim's breath, rough and small.

DOG (CONT'D)
That's all of it. I haven't left anything out.

He reaches into the fire.

He does not think. If he thought, he would not do it. Both hands into the flames to the wrists. He closes them on the pouch and lifts it out.

It is a burning coal in his hands. The sound that comes out of him is not a word. He does not drop it. He holds it before his chest as a boy holds a bird, smoke rolling into his face, tobacco hissing and popping in the burning leather.

DO NOT SHOW THE HANDS. Stay on Dog's face, extreme close. The fire in one eye. In the other, reflected small and tall, the dark shape of the creature, watching. We understand what is happening from his face, the hiss of the leather, and the sound Jim cannot make.

A long time passes. The pouch shrinks and crumbles and goes to a handful of glowing ash that sifts down between his fingers. There is nothing in his hands but heat and the dull awful red of what is left of his palms.

He opens them.

The wind comes off the river and takes the last of the smoke across the gravel and out over the water.

The creature steps into the circle of the fire. It stops in front of him, close enough that he can smell it, and it doesn't smell of wet dog or struck matches. It smells of the woods in the first hour of rain.

It looks at his hands. It lifts one of its own: enormous, gray, thick-fingered, cracked at the knuckles like his own. It reaches out slowly and touches, with one finger, the black ruin of his palm.

It does not hurt. He thought it would. The touch is light and dry. Then it is gone, and the creature's finger is gray with ash.

It looks at the ash. Then at the fire, where the notched stick lies in the coals, the notches glowing.

It nods once.

It crosses the shingle to the flat stone, stoops, and takes up the oilcloth bundle in one hand. It walks to the rock where Jim lies propped. It kneels, that size and that age, in the gravel, in the light of a fire. It lays the oilcloth in Jim's lap and draws back its hand.

Jim stares down. He stares up. His face is a ruin of tears and blood and astonishment, and a hoarse broken sound comes out of him that Dog knows at once, because he has heard it a thousand times and never once at the right moment.

A laugh.

The creature rises. It steps back from the fire and crosses to the edge of the water and stands on the last of the stones with the river going by. It turns its two open hands toward the far bank. It holds them there.

It is not a threat. It is a door.

DOG
(raw)
It'll let us go.

He lifts his hands and the world goes white, and he sets them down again and rocks, teeth locked. Jim is dragging himself toward him across the stones. Dog shakes his head.

DOG (CONT'D)
Don't. I've got you.

He gets his forearms under Jim's knees, Jim's arms around his neck, Jim's weight onto his back. He stands. It takes everything he has. He walks past the nine-foot shape without looking at it, and it lets him, and steps aside by exactly the width of one man.

EXT. THE RIVER - DAWN

Cold enough to stop the heart. It closes around his boots, his shins, his knees. The current takes hold and leans. Round stones roll underfoot. At his thighs the river is a muscle. His burned hands are held out before him like a pair of dead things.

Jim's grip slips. His arms have no strength left. The wet cold hands loosen at Dog's throat.

Dog has no hands.

He turns his head. Bends his neck. Takes the cuff of Jim's sleeve, where it hangs over his shoulder, between his teeth, and clamps down.

They go on that way, an absurd, ugly, undignified thing: somebody carrying somebody across a river by the sleeve, like a dog with a pup. The water rises to his chest. The lights on the far bank come nearer. Over the roar of the river, a long way off, a BELL begins to ring. The bell we have been waiting for since the first frame.

LONG LENS from the far bank: two small heads in a vast moving river, one carrying the other, against the pearl sky.

A tiny dry regular sound reaches Dog from his own wrist, where his forearm hooks Jim's knee. It takes him a long moment to know it.

His watch. It is ticking again.

EXT. THE FAR BANK - SUNRISE

SUPER: 4:44 AM

The sun comes up behind the trees on the side of the river they left. No gold in it: a thin pale seam along the top of the black spruce, going from pearl to the inside of a shell. Jim lies on his back on the gravel with the collar of Dog's jacket turned up against his cheek.

Across the river, the toll fire has burned down to a thread of smoke. Behind it the trees are only trees.

Dog sits beside him, knees up, hands held out on his knees, palms up, wrapped in strips of his own shirt, dark and wet. A little smoke still comes off the cloth.

DOG
I'll never hold a saw again.

He says it to the river. Not a complaint. The way you would say the time. Jim looks at the hands, and at the face above them, and shapes the words without breath.

JIM
(mouthed, subtitled)
I'm sorry.

DOG
I'm not.

Jim looks at him a long time in the thin light. It is the first time in six years he has seen Dog's face with nothing on it. Lined, burned, ten years older than at midnight, and at ease.

Jim opens the oilcloth in his lap with fingers that won't close. Fifteen twenty-dollar bills, green with mold, curled. He takes out his wallet and counts the eleven and the forty. Three hundred and fifty-one dollars. He does the other arithmetic. Six hundred, to thirty men. A hole in his chest. A Kenworth on its side in a ditch, a payment due Friday. No voice.

He looks at it. And what rises in him is a laugh. A dry hiss. It hurts. He lies on the gravel shaking with it, mouth open, no sound at all, tears running into his ears, and Dog turns and looks at him with deep concern.

Jim holds up the three hundred in his shaking hand. Points at it. Points at the river. And shapes one word with his lips, so there can be no mistake:

JIM
(mouthed, subtitled)
Interest.

Dog stares. His face comes apart slowly from the middle, like ice going out of a river. A sound comes out of him Jim has never heard in six years: a low rough cracked noise from below the ribs. He laughs. He bends over his ruined hands and laughs until he coughs, and cannot stop.

Something touches Jim's wrist. A tickle. A sting.

On the back of his hand, in the first light, sits a MOSQUITO.

A big dull gray July mosquito with long legs and a delicate, hungry, absurd attention. It sinks its needle into his skin and drinks. The first living thing he has seen all night other than the two of them and the one in the trees.

SOUND: the mosquito's whine, thin and perfect, is the first insect we have heard since the June yard. It is the loveliest sound in the film. Under it the world comes back, layer by layer: a breath of wind in the spruce, the generator, a screen door, a bird.

DOG
(wiping his eyes with his wrist)
You got your mosquito.

Jim doesn't swat it. He lies with his hand held out in the light and lets it take what it wants.

Up the slope, a screen door SLAMS. Boots on gravel, coming. Somebody shouting for the medic. A DOG BARKING: an actual dog. The best sound Jim has ever heard.

Then, from across the river: a knock.

Just one. Soft and round and clear. Wood on wood from the edge of the stones. The oldest sound Jim knows, the first anyone taught him on this grade, and for six years he answered it with a grin.

He looks. At the far water's edge, in the thin smoke, a tall gray shape stands upright, far away, only a darker patch against the gray. Quite still, hands at its sides.

His hand moves before he can stop it. An old reflex, six years deep: knuckles drawn back, the grin. He has his fist half raised to knock. He can see how it would go. The cocky double rap. Hey, forest, no hard feelings.

Dog's burned hand comes down over his wrist. It is gentle. It does not close.

Jim looks at him.

Dog shakes his head. Then he turns and looks across the water and gets up, in stages, like an old man, hands held out in front of him. He walks three steps to a driftwood log half out of the gravel at the water's edge, gray and dry and long as a canoe. He bends. He sets one bandaged elbow on the wood.

KNOCK. KNOCK.

Two. Slow, spaced, deliberate. A count, not a greeting. A man who has been given a bill and has paid it, saying so.

It carries a long way over the water, comes back off the far trees, and dies.

Dog straightens. He stands with his back to Jim, looking across at the gray shape in the smoke. When he speaks it is not loud. It is the plain, rough, ordinary voice of someone who spent nine years learning how to say nothing and has only now found out what it was for.

DOG
Thank you.

The shape stands a long time. The river goes by between them, bright now, almost gold. Then it goes down on all fours. It turns, easily, and moves into the trees without a sound, and the morning closes behind it.

Boots hit the gravel. A flashlight. A loud kind voice: jesus, jesus Christ, hold on, buddy, hold on. A man's face above Jim in a hard hat, enormous, sunburned, wet-eyed with astonishment. HANDS lift him. He lets them. He has a mosquito on his hand and the sky in his eyes and Dog's name safe behind his teeth.

Dog stands over them, hands held out in front of him, as the medics reach for him too. He lets them.

Jim, on the stretcher, catches Dog's eye. He lifts his eyebrows. A question. The old one. He holds up fingers: a number on a scale.

Dog looks at him. Thinks about it.

DOG
Four.

Jim opens his mouth for the joke. Nothing comes. He finds he doesn't need one. He lies in the arms of strangers with three hundred and fifty-one dollars in his fist and a hole in his chest and the whole bright morning going by overhead. His lips move, with great peace, shaping the last thing on his mind:

JIM
(mouthed, subtitled)
Still due Friday.

Dog, across the gravel, reads it. Almost smiles.

A mosquito whines. The river runs gold. Somewhere across it, a very long way off, wood knocks softly on wood. Once.

Jim lets it be.

SMASH TO BLACK.

THE END